In late 1959, ahead of a three-week multination tour, Eisenhower remarked that he was "doing all this just to get to India."[3] And India welcomed him with open arms. When he landed in Delhi on December 9, Secret Service officials observed that they had never experienced a reception like the one greeting the president.[4] Of the hundreds of thousands lining the streets, some shouted out, "I like Ike!" One villager even called him an avatar of the god Vishnu.[5] Speaking in the Indian parliament, which had recently been grappling with Chinese claims on what India considered its territory, Eisenhower pointedly noted that he was there "representing a nation that wants not an acre of another people's land."[6]

By early 1959, American and Indian views on the ideological threat that China posed and on how to meet the challenge had already converged. Two key developments in 1959—the intensifying Sino-Indian border dispute and an uprising in Tibet—would bring convergence in their views of China as a security threat as well. This shared perception of China affected the US-India relationship in two ways. First, it removed an obstacle to further improvement in the relationship. Second, in and of itself, it led to a strategic partnership, with joint efforts to contain China.

These efforts between 1959 and 1962 involved diplomatic, military, and economic elements. The US extended sympathy and support for India in its dispute with China. Delhi would eventually also request—and Washington would provide—American military assistance. The US also made efforts to restrain Pakistan during the Sino-Indian war of 1962. It furthermore shared intelligence with Delhi, and it encouraged its allies to aid India's military as well.

Over this period, US development assistance to India only increased. In the years just before, there had been both hope that India would succeed and fear that it might fail. By 1959, the former sense dominated, leading to discussions of whether the US should think beyond trying to help India become a successful democratic alternative to communist China to helping it become a counterbalance to that country. The idea of a Sino-Indian race had so caught on that, at a *New York Times* forum in December 1959, high school students framed their answer to a question about India's importance in terms of that competition. And as a 17-year-old from Long Island put it, "All Asia is in a sense watching both countries to see who will in a sense win out."[7]